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AI Knowledge is Power

– A Discourse Analysis of How Swedish AI-Strategies Construct Military AI Systems

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AI kunskap är makt
– En diskursanalys av hur svenska AI-strategier konstruerar militära AI-system

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"The history of war reminds us of the ever-absurd level of atrocity that we can inflict on one another. When considering that AI is designed to maximise (even exceed) human performance, then the relevancy and need for ethical analyses informing the use of AI in defence should be self-evident." - Mariarosario Taddeo

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INTRODUCTION

Globalization has long been shaped by technological innovation. Developments in transportation, communication and digital media have transformed how people, states, markets and ideas move across borders. Eriksen (2014) describes contemporary globalization as a condition of extensive interconnectedness through trade, communication and movement (Eriksen 2014: 97). While this has created new possibilities, it has also increased global dependencies and vulnerabilities (Eriksen 2014: 150). Artificial intelligence (AI) represents a more recent development within this process. Its rapid expansion increasingly affects public administration, economic competition and national security, making AI not only a technological advancement but also a political, ethical and social concern. In relation to AI used for military and defense–related purposes, autonomous weapons demonstrate some of the difficulties involved in governing a technology that can provide strategic advantages while also raising serious questions about whether these technologies will genuinely contribute to making the world safer for humanity.

The EU's AI Act provides an important point of departure for examining this issue as the first international law regulating AI. Although the regulation establishes rules intended to address risks associated with civilian AI, systems developed or used exclusively for military, defense or national security purposes fall outside its scope (AI Act 2024: Art. 2(3)). This distinction takes on greater significance in the context of lethal autonomous weapons systems (LAWS), where questions of autonomy are directly connected to the use of lethal force, as some of the applications of AI that raise the greatest ethical concerns are governed outside the regulatory framework that otherwise seeks to protect individuals and society from AI-related risks. The study therefore focuses not only on what is regulated, but on how the exclusion of military AI from international regulations is understood and justified. Sweden provides a useful case for examining these questions as it operates within the EU regulatory framework and has undergone significant changes in its security policy in response to the Russo-Ukranian War (AI Commission 2024: 46). Swedish AI strategies place considerable emphasis on technological development, international competitiveness and national security, while echoes of its history of peace, neutrality and humanitarianism provides an opportunity to explore how these different ideas are represented alongside one another as Sweden develops its approach to AI and security.

Against this background, the purpose of this study is to examine how AI for defense and security purposes is framed within EU and Swedish policy discourse. Particular attention is given to how the military exemption in the AI Act is legitimized, how military AI and LAWS are discussed in relation to security and ethics and how AI literacy is represented within Swedish AI strategies and policy recommendations. Through policy documents, interviews and observations, the study explores how professionals working with AI, politics and the public sector approach these issues. By bringing these perspectives together, the study considers a broader question surrounding the growing role of AI in society. Rather than treating AI development as something that simply happens, this study examines the political and social choices involved in deciding what role AI should have in society.

BACKGROUND

Artificial intelligence is not a new field, but the capabilities of AI systems have expanded considerably in the past decades, particularly since 2012 as a result of larger datasets, improvements in computing power and growing public and private investment (Stanford University 2024: 22–32). AI is now increasingly integrated into everyday technologies and digital services, although access remains uneven across the world (Berglez 2019: 436–437). Many appear to be in awe of what AI technologies can do and the beneficial aspects of AI systems are often highlighted (Skill & Francisco 2019: 5). But there have also been concerns raised at the capabilities and uses of these technologies globally. The expansion of AI has therefore increased pressure to determine how these systems should be governed. The European Union responded through Regulation (EU) 2024/1689, commonly referred to as the AI Act. The regulation defines an AI system as a machine-based system designed to operate with varying levels of autonomy and capable of generating outputs such as predictions, content, recommendations or decisions based on the inputs it receives (AI Act 2024: Art. 3). The Act follows a risk-based approach intended to protect health, safety and fundamental rights while supporting the development and use of AI within the EU (AI Act 2024: Art. 1).

An important limitation of this framework is its treatment of military AI. Article 2(3) excludes AI systems developed or used exclusively for military, defense or national security purposes from the scope of the regulation (AI Act 2024: Art. 2(3)). The exemption applies regardless of whether the actor involved is public or private, all the while, the EU also lacks a legal framework specifically governing the use of LAWS (Jurić 2024: 400–403). The scope of the defense exemption becomes important when AI moves from supporting military operations to making decisions over life and death using LAWS. Miller defines LAWS as weapons that, once programmed and activated, can locate, identify, track and destroy human or other targets without further intervention from a human operator (Miller 2025: 1–2). Their development has generated debate concerning human control, accountability and whether decisions over lethal force should be delegated to autonomous systems. International discussions over their regulation have taken place for more than a decade without producing a legally binding international framework specifically governing LAWS (Badell & Schmitt 2021: 242–243).

The Swedish context adds another dimension to these debates. The two main Swedish policy documents examined in this study are the AI Commission's *Roadmap for Sweden* (2024) and the Swedish governments *Sweden's AI Strategy* (2024). Both present AI as increasingly important for Sweden's public sector, economic competitiveness and national security. Rather than questioning whether AI should become more integrated into Swedish society, these documents largely focus on how Sweden can accelerate its development and use while managing the risks that accompany it (Regeringskansliet 2026: 10–15). Regarding security, the Roadmap describes Sweden and Europe as facing a severely worsened security status and argues that Swedish society must both protect itself against AI-enabled threats and make use of AI to strengthen security (AI Commission 2024: 46).

Finally, the governance of AI also depends on who understands these systems and who can participate in discussions about their use. The AI Act defines AI literacy in terms of the knowledge and skills needed to use AI in an informed manner and understand its opportunities and possible harms (AI Act 2024: Art. 4). Swedish policies similarly place considerable emphasis on improving AI literacy and competence. This is especially relevant to military AI, where the technical complexity of the subject can make it difficult for the wider public to understand and participate in discussions about its regulation. In this light, AI literacy may help bridge the gap between complex technological systems and the people they are intended to serve. A broader understanding of AI may also allow more people to participate in discussions about how the technology should be developed and used, rather than leaving these decisions primarily to governments, technical experts and private companies with their own political or commercial interests. AI literacy can therefore not only be a way of helping individuals adapt to AI, but also a means of increasing public participation in decisions about how AI can contribute to society in a meaningful way.

PURPOSE AND AIMS

The aim of this study is to examine how military AI is framed within EU and Swedish policy discourse and how these representations shape discussions of risk, security, ethics and regulation. With a particular focus on the military exemption in the AI Act, lethal autonomous weapons systems and AI literacy. The study is also motivated by a broader concern about the gap between the rapid development of AI and public knowledge about what these technologies are already capable of. While AI has become increasingly present in everyday life, applications such as autonomous weapons demonstrate that its development extends far beyond the tools most people encounter directly. One aim of this study is therefore to bring greater attention to these less visible uses of AI and encourage critical reflection on where the technology is heading, who is shaping that development and what consequences may follow. The interviews include participants with different levels of knowledge and expertise in AI, the AI Act and AI literacy, providing both expert and non-expert perspectives. This allows the study to consider how people without specialized knowledge engage with questions of AI regulation, while also examining how those with relevant expertise approach current developments. In this sense, AI literacy is relevant not only to understanding how AI works or how to use it responsibly, but also to giving citizens the knowledge needed to question its development and participate in discussions about the role it should have in society.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

The three research questions approach AI not only as a technology, but as something whose meaning and legitimacy are shaped through language. Discourse influences which aspects of AI become central to political debate, how its risks and benefits are presented and which forms of knowledge

are treated as relevant when decisions about its use are made. The inclusion of AI literacy broadens this focus by considering the public's position within these discussions. While it extends beyond discourse analysis itself, AI literacy is relevant because participation in debates about AI depends partly on having enough knowledge to critically engage with its implications. Despite its widespread use and popularity, AI remains an ambiguous concept that can be difficult for non-experts to define and understand. The three questions therefore connect the production of discourse with the ability of citizens to engage critically with it.

1. In what ways is the defense exemption in the AI Act constructed within EU and Swedish policy discourse?

2. How are military AI technologies, particularly lethal autonomous weapons systems, discursively framed in relation to wider debates on security, ethics and international governance?

3. What role does AI literacy play in public understanding and participation in debates about AI?

METHOD

This study uses Foucauldian discourse analysis to examine how AI is constructed through the EU and Swedish policy documents, interviews and scientific articles. The analysis is based primarily on Michel Foucault's The Order of Discourse (1981), which is concerned with the relationship between discourse, knowledge and power. In addition, Norman Fairclough's Discourse and Social Change (1992) draws on the perspectives of several philosophers and emphasizes that language does not merely describe the social world; discourse also helps construct social identities, relationships and systems of knowledge and belief. In accordance with this, rather than treating language as a neutral description of reality, the study approaches discourse as something that contributes to constructing what it describes in the process of describing it a certain way. As Fairclough states, discourse does not simply reflect social entities and relations but also helps constitute them (Fairclough 1992: 3). A simple way to explain discourse analysis is through the expression "think outside the box." In this metaphor, the box represents the boundaries of a particular discourse. What is inside the box can be thought, said, discussed and disputed. What lies outside is more difficult to imagine or express and may be dismissed when it is brought into the discussion. Discourse analysis can therefore be used to examine where these boundaries are drawn and how they shape what is considered thinkable and sayable at a particular time (Arribas-Ayllon & Walkerdine 2017: 111).

In keeping with Foucauldian discourse analysis, power is therefore wielded not only in terms of who makes political decisions, but also in terms of who has the authority to define AI as a risk, a necessity or a desirable form of technological progress. The analysis consequently focuses on recurring language, assumptions and representations across the empirical material. Attention is given to how national security, international competition, technological progress, ethics and responsibility are discussed. I also examine what receives comparatively little attention. This is important because discourse can establish boundaries around what appears reasonable or possible without explicitly prohibiting alternative positions. The same approach is applied to the interviews where respondents are not treated as providing an objective account of AI, but as participants who draw on, reproduce or question wider ways of speaking about technology, security and responsibility. Their responses are compared with the policy material to identify where similar assumptions appear and where alternative perspectives emerge. This approach makes it possible to analyze the military exemption, the AI arms race discourse and AI literacy as connected questions concerning knowledge and power rather than as separate policy issues. The purpose of the analysis is not simply to identify whether policy documents describe AI positively or negatively. Instead, I examine which representations of AI become dominant, which assumptions are treated as self-evident and which perspectives receive less attention.

The empirical material consists of qualitative data collected through semi-structured interviews with IT experts and public-sector professionals conducted between May and June 2026. Most participants were Swedish, while one was from Colombia, providing a perspective outside the Swedish context and allowing the study to consider how some of the issues discussed may be viewed from a different national setting. Combined with the policy documents, the interviews make it possible to analyze both formal policy discourse and how these ideas are interpreted by professionals who encounter AI and related policies in their work. Semi-structured interviews were chosen because they provide a common interview guide while leaving room for the conversation to develop according to each participant's knowledge and experience. This flexibility was useful because the study covers several fields and the respondents have different professional backgrounds. The method allowed comparable questions to be asked across the interviews while follow-up questions could clarify answers or explore unexpected themes. This also reduced the risk of limiting the interviews to assumptions already present in the interview guide. Semi-structured interviews require the researcher to remain open to unexpected insights and changes in the direction of the conversation, which can add nuance to the material and introduce perspectives that were not anticipated but equally significant (Alm 2019: 70–71).

MATERIALS AND EMPIRICAL DATA

The material used in this study consists of EU and Swedish policy documents together with six semi-structured interviews. The documents were selected because they provide material at both the EU and Swedish levels and address the three main areas examined in this study: AI regulation, military AI and AI literacy. Regulation (EU) 2024/1689, commonly known as the AI Act, forms the regulatory

foundation of the study. The regulation establishes harmonized rules for AI systems within the EU and applies directly to Sweden as an EU member state. Central to this study is Article 2(3), which excludes AI systems developed or used exclusively for military, defense or national security purposes from the scope of the regulation (AI Act 2024: Art. 2(3)). The EU material also includes the European Parliament briefing *Defence and Artificial Intelligence* (Clapp 2025). The briefing was selected because it deals more directly with military AI than the AI Act and discusses lethal autonomous weapons systems, meaningful human control and the legal questions surrounding their development. It therefore provides additional material for examining how military AI is discussed at the EU level (Clapp 2025: 1-3).

The Swedish policy material consists primarily of the government's *Sweden's AI Strategy* (2026) and the AI Commission's *Roadmap for Sweden* (2024), which will henceforth be referred to as "the AI Strategy" and "the Roadmap", respectively. The AI Strategy provides the Swedish government's overarching approach to AI and addresses areas including competitiveness, public-sector use, security and AI literacy. It also discusses AI within the defense sector, making it relevant to the study's focus on military AI (Regeringskansliet 2026: 11–13). The Roadmap was produced by Sweden's AI Commission and provides recommendations for the development and use of AI in Sweden. It also proposes how government funding should be distributed across different sectors to support Sweden's transition to increased AI use. It was selected because it discusses several issues central to this study in greater detail than the AI Strategy, including AI literacy, national security and military applications of AI. The Roadmap also discusses autonomous weapons and the legal and ethical questions associated with their development (AI Commission 2024: 48–50). When coupled, these documents provide material from different levels of AI governance. The AI Act establishes the overarching EU regulatory framework, while the European Parliament briefing provides material specifically concerning military AI. While the two Swedish documents provide the national policy context in which AI development, security and AI literacy are discussed in Sweden. The purpose of selecting these documents is not to provide an exhaustive account of all AI policy in Sweden or the EU, but to examine documents that are directly relevant to the research questions. Additionally, as this study employs discourse analysis, news and scientific articles are also included in the analysis to provide broader context and situate how AI and its regulation are discussed and represented across different settings.

The empirical material consists of semi-structured interviews with six participants whose professional backgrounds relate to AI, digitalization, politics, law, public administration, academia or information literacy. A common denominator between the participants is that they all currently work, or have worked, in the public sector, meaning they may have encountered the AI Act in their professional roles. At the same time, the diversity of their professional and national backgrounds provides perspectives from people who encounter questions surrounding AI and its governance in different contexts. Observations were also incorporated into the research process, both during and prior to the interviews, adding an ethnographic dimension to the study by providing contextual insight into the settings and interactions surrounding the participants. For reasons of anonymity, the participants will henceforth be referred to as Respondents No. 1 through 6.

- *Respondent No. 1* is a university lecturer and researcher at a Swedish university and holds a PhD in computer science. In addition to teaching and research, the respondent gives public lectures about AI. Their background provides a technical and academic perspective on AI development and public knowledge of the technology in local swedish communities.

- *Respondent No. 2* works as a digitalization strategist in a Swedish municipality, their work is related to digital tools and AI. The respondent was included to provide a municipal perspective on how digitalization and AI are addressed within the public sector.

- *Respondent No. 3* is a politician who has been active in Swedish municipal politics. The respondent was included to provide a political perspective on how AI policy and regulation are approached within municipal and regional public administration. Respondent No. 3 was included to provide insights from the perspective of a decision-maker involved in public-sector governance.

- *Respondent No. 4* is a member of the Swedish Parliament with experience from parliamentary work concerning constitutional, EU and defense matters. The respondent was selected because this experience is relevant to the study's examination of EU regulation, national security and military AI.

- *Respondent No. 5* is a university librarian in Sweden whose work includes teaching information literacy, critical source evaluation and AI literacy. This respondent was included because AI literacy forms an important part of the study and because educational institutions and libraries have a role in supporting knowledge about AI.

- *Respondent No. 6* is a digital-rights advocate and human rights lawyer from Colombia. Although the primary geographical focus of the study is Sweden and Europe, this respondent provides a perspective from outside the European context. This grants the study with a Global Studies perspective and supports its discussion of international AI governance, the digital divide and the global implications of military AI, whose development and consequences are not confined by national borders.

Ethical considerations were important throughout the interview process. Before each interview, participants were informed about the purpose of the study, how the interview material would be used and their right to withdraw their participation. Consent was obtained before the interviews were conducted and the material was included in the study. The respondents are identified by number rather than by name. Their professional backgrounds are included because they are relevant to the analysis, but personal information that is not necessary for the study has been excluded.

Complete anonymity cannot be guaranteed, particularly for respondents who hold public positions or have professional roles that may make them identifiable. For this reason, descriptions of the respondents have been kept very general while still providing the context necessary to interpret their answers.

Additional care was required because parts of the interviews concerned military AI, national security and public-sector institutions. Respondents were not asked to provide confidential or security-sensitive information and the study does not seek to identify information that is intentionally restricted for national security reasons. The study also recognizes the unequal relationship between researcher and participant that can arise during qualitative interviews. The interview questions inevitably influence the direction of the conversation and may reflect assumptions held by the researcher (Haraway 1988: 583-584). Lastly, the findings are not meant to be representative of broader professional or social groups, but rather individual perspectives.

LIMITATIONS AND SCOPE

This study is subject to several limitations. First, the discourse analysis focuses on one overarching regulatory framework, the AI Act and the focus is on what falls outside the scope of the Act, which is an important distinction throughout this study. The analysis also focuses on two Swedish AI policy documents, neither of which is legally binding. While this allows for a focused analysis of policy discourse, it cannot capture the full landscape of AI governance in Sweden or internationally. The empirical material is also based on a relatively small number of semi-structured interviews with six professionals working in or closely connected to the public sector. This group was selected because the AI Act applies in Sweden and public-sector professionals are among those who encounter its requirements and the broader implementation of AI policy in their work. The findings are therefore not intended to represent the views of the public sector as a whole. Instead, the interviews provide qualitative insight into how professionals with different backgrounds approach the issues examined in this study.

The study is also temporally bound to the period 2024–2026, during which both AI technologies and their regulatory frameworks have developed rapidly. The findings should therefore be viewed in relation to this particular period and may change as the technology, policies and surrounding discourse continue to develop. Access to information concerning military and defense applications of AI also presents a limitation. Some information is restricted for national security reasons and several respondents emphasized the limits of their own knowledge of defense matters. As a result, the study cannot provide a complete account of how military AI is developed, governed or used in practice. However, these limitations in access are themselves relevant to the discourse analysis.

Drawing on Haraway's concept of situated knowledge, the analysis is also shaped by the researcher's own position and this study acknowledges that. Haraway suggests that most knowledge, including scientific knowledge, is produced from social and intellectual positions assumed by the researcher rather than from a completely neutral standpoint. Indeed, the analysis is informed by a Global Studies perspective, which influences the questions asked and the aspects of the material that receive attention (Haraway 1988: 583-584).

Finally, it is worth mentioning that Swedish AI policy does not develop independently of wider European and international processes. Policy diffusion is relevant when considering the relationship between the AI Act and Swedish AI governance. As an EU regulation, the AI Act establishes a common regulatory framework that applies across member states, while Swedish AI policies develop within this broader European context. Hence, Swedish policy discourse should not be treated as entirely separate from developments at the EU or international level. This is also a limitation of the previous research used for this study, as much of the academic literature focuses on the United States or Europe more broadly rather than Sweden specifically. While this literature provides important context for understanding wider debates surrounding AI, military technology and governance, its findings cannot always be directly applied to the Swedish context.

LITERATURE REVIEW

The previous research included in this study was selected based on its relevance to the study's research questions concerning military AI, the regulation of LAWS, security discourse and public understanding of AI. It covers ethical and legal questions surrounding autonomous weapons, international competition and AI development, as well as the Swedish context in which military technology is developed and discussed. While much of the existing research focuses on individual aspects of military AI, bringing these studies together makes it possible to examine how questions of security, ethics, regulation and technological development intersect.

A central theme in previous research concerns the extent to which human control and responsibility can be maintained as increasingly autonomous AI systems become integrated into military decision-making. Taddeo (2024) approaches this through what she calls the "predictability problem." The combination of agency, autonomy and learning capabilities makes it difficult to determine with certainty how an AI system will behave, particularly when it encounters conditions that differ from those on which it was trained (Taddeo 2024: 2-6). In military settings, unpredictable behavior may contribute to conflict escalation, affect civilian populations, or violate principles associated with Just War Theory and international humanitarian law. Taddeo therefore connects the ethics of military AI to questions of human control and responsibility.

Miller (2025) similarly places human control at the center of the ethical debate surrounding LAWS. He defines LAWS as weapons that, once programmed and activated, can locate, identify, track and

destroy targets without further human intervention, while self-learning systems introduce additional unpredictability (Miller 2025: 1-2). However, Miller does not consider unpredictability sufficient in itself to make LAWS morally unacceptable. Instead, he posits that their permissibility depends on factors such as the degree of human control, destructive capacity, proximity of civilians and the broader military context (Miller 2025: 2-3). Since AI systems cannot themselves understand moral principles or accept moral responsibility, Miller argues that responsibility must remain with the human actors and institutions involved in their development and deployment (Miller 2025: 3-7). He therefore rejects a complete "responsibility gap" and argues that responsibility can be distributed among designers, commanders, operators, analysts and institutions.

Taddeo and Miller consequently approach the problem from slightly different directions but reach a similar concern. Taddeo emphasizes the difficulty of predicting and controlling AI behavior, while Miller concentrates more directly on how moral responsibility can remain with humans despite increasing autonomy. Taddeo also raises concerns about the dignity of those targeted when LAWS remove interpersonal relations from lethal force (Taddeo 2024: 23-26), whereas Miller focuses on institutional arrangements capable of preserving human responsibility. Jointly, their work shows that meaningful human control concerns not only whether a person remains technically involved in operating a weapon, but also whether responsibility for its actions can still be identified post-automation.

Questions of human control are closely connected to the legal status of military AI. Jurić (2024) examines military AI within the European policy context and shows that potential applications range from data analysis and cyber operations to autonomous drones and LAWS. At the same time, he problematizes how definitions and classifications differ between policy frameworks governing AI globally, complicating attempts to establish a shared approach to military AI governance (Jurić 2024: 396-399). Jurić notes that EU policy has historically separated civilian and military AI. The European Commission's 2018 AI strategy was largely silent on defense, while the 2020 White Paper explicitly excluded military AI and the AI Act similarly places defense-related applications outside its scope (Jurić 2024: 400-401). The European Parliament, however, has repeatedly raised concerns about LAWS and the need for meaningful human control (Jurić 2024: 403).

Badell and Schmitt (2022) provide a broader explanation for why a common European approach has been difficult to establish. They show that LAWS have been debated not only as a technological issue, but also in relation to human rights, international humanitarian law and arms control. The movement of discussions from the UN Human Rights Council to the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons contributed to LAWS being treated primarily as an arms-control issue rather than a human-rights issue (Badell & Schmitt 2022: 247-249). Attempts to regulate these weapons have subsequently encountered different national interests and understandings of security (Badell & Schmitt 2022: 249-251). Jurić and Badell and Schmitt therefore address different levels of the same regulatory problem. Jurić demonstrates how military AI has remained partly separated from the EU's wider approach to AI regulation, while Badell and Schmitt show how disagreements

between states have made international agreement on LAWS difficult. This is especially relevant to the present study because the exclusion of military AI from the AI Act exists within a wider international debate in which states continue to disagree about the appropriate level and form of regulation.

Another theme concerns the relationship between technological development and international security. Taddeo describes a "security paradox" in which the acquisition of military AI capabilities by one state may be perceived as threatening by others, encouraging them to develop similar capabilities. This process can contribute to hostility between states even when technological development is originally presented as necessary for national defense (Taddeo 2024: 23). Roff (2019) questions the language through which this process is described in the world today. She argues that referring to international AI competition as an "arms race" can itself encourage rivalry and escalation by leading policymakers to approach AI development primarily through military competition (Roff 2019: 97). She also criticizes the tendency to discuss AI as though it were a single technology. Since AI is generally one component within a wider technological system, Roff proposes an "AI+" approach that directs attention toward the particular system and purpose in which AI is being used (Roff 2019: 95).

Taddeo and Roff therefore both question the assumption that the development of military AI by one state can be considered independently from the behavior of others. Their approaches differ, however, in that Taddeo primarily examines the ethical risks created by this security dynamic, whereas Roff questions the discourse through which technological competition is presented as an "arms race". Roff's work is particularly relevant to this study's discourse analytical approach because it demonstrates that the language used to describe AI competition can influence how the available political responses are perceived.

While the previous studies primarily address military AI at the international or European level, Coetzee (2017) provides historical context for examining military technology in Sweden. Although his study concerns Gripen fighter aircraft rather than AI, it shows that Swedish military technological development has historically involved security concerns alongside economic interests. Sweden developed a substantial domestic defense industry partly through its policy of armed neutrality, while maintaining this industry increasingly required access to export markets (Coetzee 2017: 52–54). Coetzee also examines the relationship between Sweden's defense industry and its international identity. Sweden's association with neutrality, peace, development assistance and international cooperation has existed alongside its position as a producer and exporter of advanced military technology. Rather than treating these qualities as contradictory, Coetzee argues that Sweden's international reputation has also contributed to its defense industry positively (Coetzee 2017: 56-57). His research therefore adds an important Swedish dimension to the literature on military AI. It demonstrates that the development of military technology in Sweden has historically taken place within a wider political and economic context.

To summerize, the previous research shows that military AI governance cannot easily be separated into ethical, legal and security questions. Taddeo and Miller demonstrate the difficulties surrounding unpredictability, human control and responsibility, while Jurić and Badell and Schmitt show how these concerns interact with fragmented approaches to military AI regulation. Roff adds a discourse-oriented perspective by questioning how the language of an AI "arms race" can shape understandings of technological competition, while Coetzee places military technological development within the specific historical and political context of Sweden. The present study brings these strands of research together by examining how military AI is discussed within Swedish and European policy discourse and how the exclusion of military AI from the AI Act is presented and justified. It further expands this discussion through interviews with people working in politics, AI and the public sector. The study also considers AI literacy and the ability of non-specialists to participate in discussions surrounding AI governance. This is relevant because, as Roff's work demonstrates, how AI is defined and discussed can affect how its risks and possible responses are perceived (Roff 2019: 95-97).

ANALYSIS

The Ethics of Lethal Autonomous Weapon Systems

The origins of artificial intelligence can be traced back to Dartmouth in 1956, when John McCarthy, Marvin Minsky, Nathaniel Rochester and Claude Shannon proposed a summer research project on artificial intelligence. The group consisted of scholars from fields such as mathematics, neurology and information science and the proposal was based on the idea that "every aspect of learning or any other feature of intelligence" could be described precisely enough for a machine to replicate it (McCarthy et al. 2006: 12). However, it was not until more recently that the technical capacity emerged to create the kinds of AI systems that they had envisioned. Modern AI systems are especially powerful because they can identify patterns in very large datasets and generate outputs at a speed and scale that humans cannot match. Yet, AI can only outperformhuman beings in doing narrow and clearly defined tasks. Fuethermore, contemporary AI systems operate with increasing levels of autonomy. AI's capacity has grown rapidly since 2012 due to the availability of large datasets, major improvements in computing power and increased public and private investment (Stanford University 2024: 22–32). Today, AI is increasingly commercialized and embedded in ordinary digital services and appliences, including search engines, customer service systems, robot vacuum cleaners and vehicles with automated driving functions. AI is therefore becoming increasingly present in the more technologically developed parts of the world, in particular, as the digital divide still means that access to technology is unequal in different parts of the world (Berglez 2019: 436-437). Nevertheless, AI's growing presence in everyday life, rapid development and impact on both societies and the natural environment make its proliferation more than simply a question of technological progress. In this thesis, my aim is to examine how AI can also be understood as a political, ethical and social concern and what implications this may have for Swedish society.

The analysis in this study will be conducted through the lens of Foucauldian discourse analysis. This means that I am interested in examining how particular ways of speaking about AI make the military exemption appear reasonable, necessary or problematic and how these understandings shape which responses to AI systems are considered possible. This is particularly relevant as AI becomes increasingly integrated into society while knowledge about its capabilities, risks and regulation remains unevenly distributed. In Foucault's essay The Order of Discourse (1981), the power of discourse lies partly in its ability to establish the boundaries of what can be meaningfully thought, said and acted upon. Through this logic, Foucault posits that it is through discourse that societal structures can be created, transformed or maintained (Foucault 1981: 52–53). Applied to this study, this means examining not only what Swedish policy and public-sector professionals say about AI, but also which understandings of AI are given authority, which risks and benefits receive attention and which possible responses become more difficult to imagine. This allows the analysis to consider how discourse shapes the way AI is understood and governed in Swedish society.

Before discussing the ethics of AI, it is necessary to establish how AI is defined within the regulatory framework that governs it. Regulation (EU) 2024/1689 (the AI Act) defines an "AI system" as a machine-based system designed to operate with varying levels of autonomy and that, based on the inputs it receives, infers how to generate outputs such as predictions, content, recommendations, or decisions (AI Act 2024: Art. 3). The AI Act was introduced by the European Union (EU) to address the risks associated with AI while supporting the development and use of safe and trustworthy systems. It seeks to protect health, safety, fundamental rights, democracy and the rule of law through a risk-based regulatory approach. Different requirements are imposed depending on the risks associated with a particular AI system or use, with certain practices prohibited altogether and others subject to strict requirements. The AI Act also establishes requirements concerning transparency, accountability and risk management for public and private actors operating within its scope (AI Act 2024: Art. 1). However, AI systems developed or used exclusively for military, defense, or national security purposes fall outside this framework (AI Act 2024: Art. 2(3)). The AI Act provides an important legal point of departure for this study for three reasons. First, it is one of the first major legislative frameworks of its kind. Second, it applies directly to Sweden, as Sweden is a member of the EU. Third, its exclusion of AI systems developed or used exclusively for military, defense, or national security purposes raises important questions about how AI is conceptualized and governed in certain contexts. This exemption is of particular interest for this study because some of the AI applications associated with the most serious ethical concerns, including autonomous weapons, are governed outside the regulatory framework that otherwise seeks to protect individuals and society from the potential risks posed by AI.

The interviews that were done with public-sector professionals illustrate how this "regulatory gap" can be justified through the state's responsibility to protect its national security and maintain control over defense matters (Jurić 2024: 395). Respondent No. 4, a member of the Swedish parliament, argues that the military should have significant autonomy from political institutions and that military matters should primarily be governed internally through the military chain of command. Respondent No. 6, a digital rights advocate and human-rights lawyer in Colombia, similarly explains

the military exemption through the state's responsibility to provide security. According to Respondent No. 6, the state promises to protect its population, their families and their property. They mean that this creates an expectation that the military should have "the best of the best", in terms of technology, to fulfil this responsibility. The Respondent goes on by saying that this is the reason why "in law there's always exceptions for military," while simultaneously warning that militaries may be particularly prone to abuses of power because "they have a lot of power" that is often "obscure" and "opaque". From a Foucauldian perspective, discourse participates in producing relations of power by shaping what is accepted as knowledge and determining which actors are positioned as legitimate authorities, Fairclough tells us that discourse is socially constructive, constituting social subjects, social relations and systems of knowledge and belief and the study which, in term, has socially constructive and ideological effects (Fairclough 1992: 36). In the examples above, the respondents describe the military as responsible for national security and civilian protection. This language does more than describe the role of military institutions; it places the military in a position where national security is given priority over the legal restrictions and scrutiny applied to civilian uses of AI, thereby justifying their preferential treatment within existing structures of power.

The military exemption becomes particularly significant when considering lethal autonomous weapons systems (LAWS), one of the most controversial applications of AI in warfare. Miller (2025) defines LAWS as weapons that, once programmed and activated, can locate, identify, track and destroy human or other targets without further intervention from a human operator (Miller 2025: 1–2). The controversial nature of these systems is reflected in United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres' description of LAWS as "politically unacceptable and morally repugnant" while calling for their prohibition under international law (United Nations 2018). Apropos the absence of binding international regulation of LAWS, the Stop Killer Robots campaign, established in 2013, advocates for international regulation and the prohibition of autonomous weapons systems. Since 2013, the question of how LAWS should be governed has been discussed within UN disarmament forums, although states have yet to reach agreement on a legally binding regulatory framework (Badell & Schmitt 2021: 242–243). Stop Killer Robots, supported by non-governmental organizations including Human Rights Watch and Amnesty International, has described autonomous weapons as potentially constituting a "third revolution in warfare," following gunpowder and nuclear weapons, reflecting their potential to transform how armed conflicts are fought and experienced by combatants and civilians around the globe (Stop Killer Robots 2025).

But like any other disruptive technology, the debate surrounding LAWS is not limited to their potential harms. Stop Killer Robots remark that supporters of LAWS argue that autonomous weapons could reduce collateral damage through greater precision while increasing the speed and efficiency of military operations. Such systems may also provide advantages in environments where communications are unreliable, reduce the exposure of soldiers to danger and potentially strengthen deterrence. In theory, LAWS could therefore reduce some of the human costs of warfare while providing states possessing the most advanced systems with a strategic advantage (Stop Killer Robots 2025). This potential is also reflected in the interviews. Respondent No. 1, who has a computer science lecturer and researcher, acknowledges that greater accuracy and efficiency could,

in principle, reduce civilian casualties and therefore constitute a positive use of autonomous military technology. Respondents No. 3, 4 and 5 similarly recognize that such technologies would aid Sweden's ability to defend itself against foreign aggressors. Respondent No. 1 illustrates this distinction by pointing to what they consider defensive applications of AI that have strengthened Israel's security, while noting that AI systems used to identify potential targets have been considerably more controversial.

> **Respondent No.1:** "There are also examples of autonomous weapons systems that have been very successful, or at least positive in some respects. In Israel, there are several such systems, including the Iron Dome. Iron Dome is an autonomous system that shoots down missiles. It is an entirely defensive system that protects Israel from missile attacks coming from surrounding areas.
>
> They also have, for example, the Gospel, which is another autonomous weapons system. It uses AI to try to identify where people believed to be terrorists in Gaza are likely to be located. In that sense, it can increase their security, because it helps them make what they regard as good decisions when locating potential terrorist organizations or targets. At the same time, things can also go very wrong when one relies on these kinds of systems. There can be a lot of criticism when mistakes happen."

The respondents' distinction is significant because it demonstrates that attitudes towards military AI are not necessarily divided into simple positions of support or opposition. A system intended to intercept incoming weapons can be perceived as enhancing security and protecting human life, whereas the use of AI to identify human targets raises more difficult questions about error and responsibility. Similar concerns are raised by the Stop Killer Robots campaign, which identifies several risks associated with autonomous weapons. These include the possibility that replacing soldiers with machines could make military action more politically acceptable while shifting greater risks onto civilians and critical infrastructure. Although the campaign approaches the issue from an advocacy perspective, several of these concerns are also supported in academic research. Taddeo (2024), for example, argues that increasing autonomy in military AI can reduce human control and responsibility while introducing unpredictability into military decision-making, with potentially serious consequences (Taddeo 2024: 2–3).

Accountability is particularly important in this context. Although the laws governing warfare and international humanitarian law (IHL) continue to apply in the face of LAWS, autonomous weapons raise questions about who should be held responsible when unlawful harm occurs. Responsibility may become difficult to assign between the programmer, manufacturer, commander and other human actors involved in the system. This corresponds with what Stop Killer Robots describes as an accountability gap and with Taddeo's broader concern that increasing autonomy may weaken the connection between human control and moral responsibility in warfare (Taddeo 2024: 48). The respondents also raise concerns that extend beyond the functioning of the technology itself.

Respondents No. 4 and No. 6 identify authoritarian leaders and the diffusion of autonomous weapons to militias and non-state actors as potential dangers associated with the proliferation of LAWS. Ultimately, Stop Killer Robots argues that autonomous weapons, like landmines, cluster munitions and nuclear weapons, should not have to claim hundreds of thousands of victims before being prohibited through international treaties (Stop Killer Robots 2025).

As concerns the discourse on the automation of defense industries, the campaign also criticizes the "AI arms race" framing, which refers to the language that major global powers use when referring to there being a competition to develop increasingly advanced autonomous weapons systems among states. Stop Killer Robots argue that large military powers and weapons manufacturers use geopolitical rivalry to justify the proliferation of autonomous weapons in order to profit. The campaign challenges the framing that makes competition appear necessary by instead presenting the arms race as a discourse that serves the interests of powerful military and commercial actors. According to this perspective, such discourse risks misallocating public resources, increasing tensions and therefore making conflict more likely. The campaign further argues that conflicts involving LAWS raise concerns about dehumanization because fully autonomous weapons can only process humans as data points rather than recognize them as human subjects (Stop Killer Robots 2025).

To add to this, as I was conducting the interviews, I noticed that the morality of autonomous weapons remains contested among public-sector professionals. Though some respondents were not aware of what LAWS were nor how they were being governed at the beginning of the interviews, the majority of them, namely Respondents No. 1, 2, 3 and 6 all expressed concern about delegating decisions over life and death to AI systems without sufficient human oversight. Though they still acknowledge the strategic benefits of such technologies, they conveyed discomfort and expressed that the implications of LAWS were alarming. Respondent No. 1 argued that autonomous weapons risk creating a situation in which "violence has been automated" and responsibility for its consequences becomes increasingly difficult to locate.

> **Me:** "What is your view of autonomous weapons systems?"

> **Respondent No. 1:** "I think they are incredibly problematic. I think one should be very careful with weapons that do not require human approval. If a weapon can fire missiles, or something similar, without human approval, then in some sense violence has been automated in a way that I do not think is really the direction humanity wants to go in. [...] even if we have a system that helps identify a target, I still think there must be a human being who makes the decision about whether or not to attack. Someone has to be responsible for that decision. If the system is allowed to decide by itself, then no one has to feel guilty when people die. That may sound cynical, but I think someone must decide whether this [act] is right or wrong."

Taddeo develops a similar argument, namely that LAWS lack human traits, such as interpersonal relationships through which opponents can recognize and respect each other's human dignity. The author states that an autonomous system does not possess the contextual understanding involved in human judgment and may therefore fail to interpret circumstances that should prevent an attack. For example, it may fail to recognize that a person is communicating generally accepted signs of surrender, potentially resulting in what Taddeo describes as a "morally problematic killing" (Taddeo 2024: 26). This also complicates the argument that autonomous weapons could make warfare more discriminate through greater precision. She asserts that the ability to identify and strike a target precisely is not necessarily equivalent to the ability to judge whether that target should be struck. Taddeo further argues that ethical considerations are often treated as secondary in discussions surrounding the digital transformation of defense. She claims that, at best, ethics is treated as an additional consideration rather than an integral part of technological development; at worst, it is perceived as an obstacle to achieving strategic advantage over adversaries (Taddeo 2024: 27). The concerns expressed by the respondents reflect this issue. Respondent No. 3, who is a politician working at a municipality in Sweden, questions whether lethal decisions can be meaningfully delegated to systems that lack moral judgment while also raising the problem of who can be held accountable when such systems cause harm.

> **Respondent No. 3:** "AI is not equipped with feelings or ethical and moral judgment. When we talk about war and warfare, it is the human that must make very balanced assessments, where people's lives and health are placed first. I am afraid that AI would not make that prioritization. That makes it quite frightening not to limit it [LAWS] either. Who is going to be responsible if something goes wrong and these autonomous weapons happen to destroy an entire village somewhere, with all its people? Who is responsible for that decision? Who will be put on trial for war crimes?"

The respondents also address the importance of meaningful human control (MHC), a concept that has become central to debates surrounding the governance of autonomous weapons. Despite this, the respondents' positions on the regulation of LAWS were not entirely clear-cut. Several respondents recognized the ethical and legal risks associated with autonomous weapons while also acknowledging the security dilemma created by their development in other states. Despite this uncertainty, the respondents generally emphasized the importance of maintaining meaningful human control and ensuring that the development and use of autonomous weapons remain consistent with human rights. This concern is also reflected by Miller, who argues that LAWS are not inherently immoral, but become morally problematic when lethal force is detached from meaningful human control. Since AI systems cannot understand moral principles, assume moral responsibility, or be held accountable for their actions, responsibility for lethal decisions must ultimately remain with human actors and institutions (Miller 2025: 4). Miller maintains that the moral acceptability of LAWS depends on the conditions under which they are used. In the case of human-in-the-loop systems, he argues that their use may, "at least in principle," be morally permissible when it complies with IHL, the Law of Armed Conflict (LOAC) and principles of Just War Theory such as proportionality and military necessity (Miller 2025: 9). Perhaps meaningful

human control offers a possible way of addressing this dilemma, as an alternative to a prohibition, by preserving human responsibility for lethal decisions while allowing states to develop and use military AI capabilities. In summary, the debate over LAWS centers on where the limits of autonomy should be drawn. While their military value is recognized, both the respondents and the literature suggest that delegating lethal decisions to AI becomes particularly problematic when meaningful human control is lost. This raises the question of whether current AI policies in Sweden also reflect these concerns, particularly as states seek to advance their military AI capabilities in an increasingly unstable world.

Swedish National AI Governance

Although the AI Act is important for explaining the motivation behind this study, the main documents used to examine the discourse on AI governance in Sweden are the AI Commission's *Roadmap for Sweden* (2024) and *Sweden's AI Strategy* (2026). The Roadmap, published in November of 2024, provides a broad reform agenda for Sweden's AI ecosystem. Across its 136 pages, the Roadmap examines the risks and opportunities associated with the proliferation of AI and outlines the investments and reforms considered necessary to facilitate Sweden's AI transition (AI Commission 2024: 3–4). The AI Strategy, published in 2026, is the Government's overarching political strategy document and states that the AI Commission's Roadmap served as one of its sources of input. The AI Strategy consists of 24 pages, making it the more "manageable" option, in terms of length, for people interested in reading about how the government plans to integrate AI into Swedish society. The AI Strategy is strongly innovation-oriented and states that EU regulation should be simple and clear, while rights and security must be protected (Regeringskansliet 2026: 9-11). Unlike the AI Act, these documents are not legally binding and focus primarily on the broader societal adoption of AI, particularly in the public and commercial sectors.

The strongest shared framing of AI in the Roadmap and the AI Strategy is that Sweden must harness AI to strengthen efficiency in the public sector, increase their competitiveness in the world market and bolster national security. The policy documents do not question whether AI should become an increasingly integrated part of Swedish society. Rather, AI is framed as a global and ongoing structural transformation to which Sweden must actively respond. The Roadmap describes Sweden as having strong institutional and technological conditions to be at the forefront of AI development, while also referencing the Global AI Index when warning about how the country is falling behind in AI development to illustrate why they believe that Sweden needs to speed up the process (AI Commission 2024: 9-10). And similar concerns have also been raised about the EU as a whole (Clapp 2025: 11). This creates a sense of urgency around the expectation that the state needs to establish the conditions necessary for the societal diffusion of AI, both to improve efficiency and to ensure that Sweden can compete with other countries in these developments (AI Commission 2024: 10). The competitiveness framing is strengthened further in the Swedish AI Strategy. The strategy sets the goal that Sweden should become one of the ten leading AI nations and links AI development directly to national competitiveness. Within this framing, legal rules are presented in two ways, both

as necessary for safeguards, but also as potential obstacles to innovation. The AI Strategy states that the government will work to ensure that AI regulation at the EU level does not inhibit innovation and that existing regulations are reformed to contribute to growth, for example (Regeringskansliet 2026: 9).

In terms of how AI is discursively constructed, these documents are not simply positive about AI, their formulations also establish certain assumptions about AI implementation as the starting point from which AI policy can be discussed. Arribas-Ayllon and Walkerdine (2017) explain that, for Foucault, discourse concerns systems of knowledge that establish the limits of what can be thought and said within a particular historical context (Arribas-Ayllon & Walkerdine 2017: 111-112). Therefore, it is important to note that the necessity of AI adoption has largely been removed from debate and made invisible to the reader, which reflects how Western society constructs the idea of "modernity" through industrialization, technological development and relative power. As Escobar (1988) argues, "Modernity as such thus remains primarily a European experience that has sought to become universal" (Escobar 1988: 438), suggesting that Western ideas of development and progress can come to be treated as universal standards. AI may similarly be seen not only as a technology, but as a contemporary measure through which states are positioned as technologically advanced or as falling behind. As a result, assumptions are made that stem from historical patterns, where the question is no longer whether Sweden should pursue widespread AI adoption, but rather how quickly and effectively AI adaptation can be achieved. Read through Foucault, by repeatedly presenting AI development as necessary for Sweden to remain competitive, increased AI adoption is constructed as the rational response to the risk of falling behind. The negative connotations associated with "falling behind" further reinforce this framing by implicitly presenting the alternative as "slowing progress".

Moreover, this optimistic framing of AI is also critically examined by Skill and Francisco (2019), who explore how AI and data are constructed as solutions to complex sustainability problems and on the United Nations Development Programme's social media and how optimistic representations of these technologies come to dominate the discourse. Their empirical material consists primarily of social media posts (tweets) published by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) and related materials (Skill & Francisco 2019: 3–4). The authors find that AI is presented as capable of addressing problems ranging from food shortages and climate change to corruption and public-sector inefficiency, much like in the Swedish policy recommendations. The UNDP's online discourse is characterized by terms such as "revolution," "formidable tool," and "tremendous potential for progress," while problems and risks are mainly discussed in documents linked to the tweets. This shows us how more nuanced representations of AI can become less visible and less accessible through what aspects institutions choose to spotlight (Skill & Francisco 2019: 5). The authors argue that this reflects a broader techno-optimism within the UNDP that may shape people's perceptions of AI and data. By presenting these technologies as solutions to complex societal problems, such discourse may make both the public and actors within the development sector less inclined to critically examine their limitations and the possibility that their implementation could do more harm than good if the social and cultural contexts of affected communities are overlooked. This is especially important when these communities lack the resources, technological access, or knowledge

needed to participate in decisions surrounding the technology, positioning them as passive recipients rather than active participants in the digital transformation (Skill & Francisco 2019: 5–7). This also highlights the importance of AI literacy as a form of agency, since the ability to understand and critically engage with AI can affect whether people are able to participate in decisions concerning technologies that may directly affect them.

Furthermore, as Respondent No. 6 highlights and Skill and Francisco similarly observe, AI is an ambiguous term that encompasses a wide range of technological tools. As the authors explain, "AI is seldom defined or explored in detail, something that allows for different interpretations and a possibility to load the technology with a variety of expectations" (Skill & Francisco 2019: 6). The ambiguity of the umbrella term "AI," combined with the tendency to emphasize its potential benefits for society, may contribute to applications such as LAWS receiving less public attention. A public primarily exposed to narratives about AI solving societal problems may remain largely unaware of its development and application in autonomous weapons, for instance. This representation of AI can therefore shape public opinion not only through what is emphasized, but also through which applications of AI technology that remains outside public awareness. Skill and Francisco do not argue that AI is inherently dangerous; rather, they demonstrate how techno-optimistic representations can make its risks and political implications less visible (Skill & Francisco 2019: 9–10). This provides an important connection to LAWS, as positive representations of AI in one context may contribute to a broader understanding of the technology that leaves its more controversial applications unquestioned.

Regarding how AI systems for defense purposes are portrayed in the policy recommendations, there is a slight but notable difference between the Roadmap and the AI Strategy. The AI Commission is considerably more explicit about the risks associated with LAWS than the AI Strategy, which primarily addresses what Taddeo calls "sustainment and support" and "adversarial and non-kinetic" uses of military AI. These include logistics, strategic decision-making and cyber operations. Taddeo distinguishes these from "adversarial and kinetic uses" where AI systems are integrated into combat, ranging from threat identification to lethal autonomous weapons systems (Taddeo 2024: xii–xiii). The AI Strategy highlights AI's potential to monitor sparsely populated territories and detect patterns in large volumes of data, for example, while it emphasizes strengthening civilian-military AI research and encouraging private investment in security and defense. Although the AI Strategy refers to "autonomous systems" as increasingly important for future battlefields, it does not elaborate on what these systems entail or address the regulation and ethical implications of LAWS (Regeringskansliet 2026: 11). The Roadmap, by contrast, acknowledges the potentially serious consequences of autonomous weapons and emphasizes compliance with IHL. It also points to the need for national regulation and notes the Swedish Defense Commission's call for ethical guidelines for AI in the defense sector. The Roadmap also promotes international cooperation in AI development and safety, pointing to existing AI safety institutes in Japan, Singapore, the United Kingdom and the United States and calling for cooperation through joint research, shared standards and exchanges between national institutes. Such initiatives may offer a different response to international AI development, based on cooperation rather than competition and mutual suspicion. Yet, while the Roadmap acknowledges the lack of binding regulation specifically governing military

AI and autonomous weapons, its recommendations cannot in themselves close this regulatory gap (AI Commission 2024: 51–52):

> "The risks associated with systems capable of killing without human involvement are self-evident, and the current lack of clear international legal regulation governing such weapons is problematic. Both the UN and the International Committee of the Red Cross have called for urgent attention to the many complex issues surrounding autonomous weapons. […] the Defence Commission has recently called for ethical guidelines regarding AI in the defence sector. These are intended to address the specific legal and ethical challenges associated with AI in military applications." (AI Commission 2024: 48-51)

To conclude, the policy discourse leaves little room to question whether Sweden should pursue civilian and commercial AI development, while leaving more uncertainty around how its most consequential military applications should be governed. This uncertainty does not stem from a lack of awareness, as the AI Commission recognizes both the serious consequences of autonomous weapons and the absence of clear international regulation. However, the emphasis on competitiveness and the risk of falling behind makes continued AI development appear necessary before the boundaries of its acceptable military use have been fully established.

The AI "Arms Race"

A reoccurring theme from both the literature, policies and interviews is the arms race framing, both as an argument for and as an argument against LAWS. An arms race can broadly be described as military competition between states involving rivalry, military build-ups and increasing arms expenditures as states seek to maintain or gain an advantage over one another (Roff 2019: 97). With the nuclear arms race during the Cold War being the most prominent historical example (McInerney 2024: 2). Although neither of the policy recommendations explicitly describes AI development as an "arms race," both reproduce several of the assumptions on which such a discourse depends. AI development is presented through international competition and the risk of falling behind, while having certain technological capabilities is explicitly connected to geopolitical and military power. The Roadmap claims that the United States and China are in the lead in regard to AI development while Europe struggles to keep pace: "While nations such as the United States and China lead the development, the EU is struggling to keep pace with this rapid technological transformation." (AI Commission 2024: 57). McInerney maintains that the arms race framing places the US and China at the center of the debate (McInerney 2024: 1-2). McInerney identifies the global AI arms race primarily as a competition between the United States and China and although Sweden is not a central actor in this rivalry, Respondent No. 4 illustrates how concerns surrounding Chinese technological influence are reflected in Swedish political institutions. This example emerged during a discussion of data protection and confidentiality in public administration, when Respondent No.

4 was asked whether there were clear guidelines governing the use of AI and digital technologies in their work.

> **Me:** "And are there clear guidelines that you have to follow?"

> **Respondent No. 4:** "Yes, there absolutely are. I can't have TikTok on my phone. Because they're afraid of Chinese spies. Not on a parliamentary phone either. But I can have Instagram and Facebook and use it as a work tool or whatever, but TikTok is a "no no" and those guidelines have been there from the beginning."

In a similar fashion, the policy documents identify the United States and China as dominant actors in the technological infrastructure underpinning AI. The Roadmap states that much of the world's computing power is concentrated in these two countries and that American and Chinese tech companies occupy dominant positions in both global and European markets. It also raises concerns about European dependence on foreign cloud services and critical technologies, presenting this as a potential vulnerability for privacy, data control and national security (AI Commission 2024: 47). The AI Strategy expresses similar concerns that AI development creates dependencies across the technological supply chain, particularly in relation to semiconductors, computing power and data centers and explicitly calls for Sweden to reduce its "vulnerabilities and dependencies" (Regeringskansliet 2026: 20). These concerns demonstrate that technological dependence is not only treated as an economic-competition issue but also as a question of security and strategic autonomy, which is reflected in Respondent No. 4's experience of restrictions on Chinese-owned technologies within the Swedish parliament. However, the question remains why Chinese-owned platforms are treated as a security concern while US-based social media platforms are considered more acceptable. This distinction may partly reflect Sweden's close strategic partnership and military alliance with the United States. McInerney argues that the AI arms race discourse has largely emerged from the United States, which constructs China as its principal technological competitor, thereby positioning the rivalry in broader terms of competition between China and the West.

> "The idea of an artificial intelligence (AI) arms race between China and the United States is ubiquitous. Before 2016, there were fewer than 300 Google results for "AI arms race" and only a handful of articles that mentioned the phrase. Today, an article on the subject gets added to LexisNexis virtually every week, and Googling the term yields more than 50,000 hits' (Zwetsloot, Toner and Ding, 2018)." (McInerney 2024: 2)

McInerney traces the spread of this language in the United States from leaders of the tech industry to politicians and national institutions. This has been accompanied by concrete policies aimed at maintaining American technological advantage, including restrictions on semiconductor exports to

China and US investment in Chinese technology (McInerney 2024: 2). The language used by American institutions is particularly significant. The US National Security Commission on Artificial Intelligence argued that the country "must win the AI competition" with China, thereby presenting technological development as a contest in which one state's progress threatens the position of the other (McInerney 2024: 1). The United States portrayal of the so-called "AI arms race" is important in shaping Swedish discourse as the United States has considerable influence over global media discourse. Berglez explains that small countries' usually follow what major powers and their media report, claiming that the US has set the agenda for how Western countries, including Sweden, have reported on security policy issues at a global level over the past few decades (Berglez 2019: 437). McInerney's article also shows how the competition framing associated with AI development or LAWS proliferation is amplified, the focus is less on self-defense and deterrence and more on technological dominance. But McInerney argues that this discourse is inflamatory and makes restraint and international cooperation appear less realistic (McInerney 2024: 2).

Roff shares this view and points to another powerful figure in the global arena, Vladimir Putin, as someone who contributed to the AI arms-race framing by stating that "whoever becomes the leader in this space [AI] will become the ruler of the world" (Roff 2019: 97). Similarly, Clapp (2025) states that some experts argue there can be "no winners" in an AI arms race and advocate prioritizing AI applications that benefit society over a military-first approach: "there can be no winners in an AI arms race [...] the world's superpowers must work together to make sure that AI benefits humanity rather than destroying it" (Clapp 2025: 3). In failing to do so, the discourse may simultaneously divert attention from the societal benefits these policies seek to promote through the use of AI and leave citizens less informed about both the military implications of AI and more immediate democratic concerns related to civilian uses of AI, including disinformation, cyber insecurity and data leakage.

Concerns surrounding China extend beyond technological competition to the physical infrastructure and resources required for AI development, adding another geopolitical dimension to the technology. As the policy documents acknowledge, access to AI depends on global supply chains and access to certain resources. The AI Strategy connects AI infrastructure to supply-chain vulnerabilities involving semiconductors and rare earth elements (Regeringskansliet 2026: 13–16). The strategy also states that AI can strengthen national security while creating risks for individuals and society by creating new forms of dependence even though it is promoted as a means of strengthening Sweden's security and independence (Regeringskansliet 2026: 6). This corresponds with Eriksen's discussion of globalization, where increasing interdependence and the fragmentation of supply chains change the risk environment by making developments in one part of the world consequential elsewhere (Eriksen 2014: 150). Respondent No. 1 raises similar concerns by shifting attention away from the capabilities of AI systems themselves and towards the physical infrastructure on which they depend. Greater reliance on AI for national defense may strengthen certain capabilities, but it can also create strategic vulnerabilities. Data centers, semiconductor production and other parts of the AI supply chain can therefore become security concerns in their own right. Respondent No. 1 first illustrates this through the vulnerability of data centers:

> **Respondent No. 1:** "A very large share of the chips used in this kind of technology are manufactured in Taiwan. Because of this, it has become an international interest to prevent Taiwan from falling into China's hands. From a historical perspective, there is not necessarily an obvious reason for the United States to come out and say, 'We intend to defend Taiwan.' Why would they do that? […] It therefore becomes a political contest in which potential conflicts and threats can emerge. If we rely too heavily on different AI technologies as a way of protecting our countries, then that makes us vulnerable to, say if an external actor takes out a data center. So, the infrastructure becomes vulnerable to external threats."

The arms race discourse therefore has consequences beyond encouraging states to develop military AI more quickly in order to compete with each other. By organizing the debate around which state will lead and which will fall behind, it can also narrow the purposes for which AI development is imagined, shifting the focus from universally beneficial uses of AI that extend beyond one country's borders. International cooperation on beneficial applications of AI receives less attention when technological progress is primarily discussed in terms of competition and strategic advantage. From a Foucauldian perspective, the dominance of the arms race narrative may therefore leave less room for imagining AI development as a shared project in which states cooperate over beneficial technologies while collectively restricting those considered too dangerous (Arribas-Ayllon & Walkerdine 2017: 115). Fairclough describes this phenomenon by stating that discourses also act as systems of rules which make it possible for some statements but not others to occur at particular times, places and institutional locations (Fairclough 1992: 40). Moreover, despite national security being framed as the motivation behind this competition rhetoric, as Respondent No. 1 points out, greater investment in AI does not necessarily lead to greater national autonomy if the entire lifecycle of the technology is not considered. Efforts to strengthen national security through AI may create new vulnerabilities when the technology remains dependent on foreign infrastructure, in addition to feeding into a competitive mindset that makes international cooperation and multilateral regulations appear increasingly difficult to achieve.

Russia, Ukraine and Deterrence

The Roadmap frames military AI primarily through risk, especially in relation to autonomous weapons. It warns that AI could be used to develop weapons capable of acting offensively "without human control" and describes systems that can kill "without human decision-making" as an obvious risk for humanity. It also identifies the absence of clear international legal regulation as problematic and notes that both the UN and the International Committee of the Red Cross have called for urgent attention to the questions surrounding autonomous weapons. Moreover, they state that the unpredictability of AI-driven security systems, warning that these are systems that may react too quickly or incorrectly to perceived threats, causing escalation without human involvement or understanding and that this is a "future risk connected to the military application of AI", however,

it appears like the kind of events that they describe have already taken place, albeit outside of Sweden (AI Commission 2024: 47-51).

To give an instance, the British Broadcasting Company (BBC) has reported that, in August of 2026, Russian authorities accused Ukraine of carrying out a drone strike on a Black Sea beach, killing seven people, including three children, with a total of forty people injured. Moscow described the incident as a deliberate attack on civilians, while Ukraine had not immediately commented on the incident. According to the BBC, some Ukrainian Telegram channels claimed that the drone crashed onto the beach because electronic warfare jammed its signal. This incident shows how autonomous weapons, in this case, in the form of drones, can cause unforeseen consequences similar to those described by the Roadmap. Although this specific example occurred after the Roadmap was published, this shows that the "future risk" that they predicted has ensued. In addition to this, Russian drones have claimed the lives of many civilians in Ukraine since the invasion of Ukraine in 2022, demonstrating that although AI-enabled military technologies are often framed as making warfare more precise or discriminate, this is not always the case in practice (AI Commission 2024: 48). Whether civilian harm results from deliberate targeting, technical failure or interference such as jamming, these technologies have proven to have severe humanitarian consequences (BBC 2026). Taddeo similarly notes that military AI remains vulnerable to technical errors, as even minor visual changes have caused AI systems to misidentify stripes as school buses. Such errors complicate claims that AI makes warfare more precise, even if that may have been the objecive (Taddeo 2024: 9).

Framing the dangers of autonomous weapons as a "future risk" can therefore be interpreted as problematic when juxtaposed with the urgency with which AI proliferation and armament are discussed elsewhere. This matters because it risks pushing the most visibly harmful forms of AI and the safeguards needed to govern them, to the margins of broader AI policy discourse. A similar concern is raised by Stop Killer Robots, which notes that while supporters of autonomous weapons often argue that LAWS may be more precise, reduce collateral damage, save soldiers' lives and strengthen deterrence, critics warn that autonomous systems can behave unpredictably in real-world environments and thereby increase risks for both soldiers and civilians (Stop Killer Robots 2025). This shows why future-oriented AI policy discourse can be problematic, by treating the most severe harms as future possibilities and not the lived experiences of real people affected by conflict.

Still, within both the policy documents and the interviews, concerns about regulation are repeatedly weighed against the demands of national security and self-defense. Most respondents expressed reservations about autonomous weapons, but these concerns rarely translated into outright opposition to their development. Instead, several respondents reasoned that if other states continue developing LAWS, Sweden and its allies cannot afford to refrain from doing the same. This doesn't mean that the argument in favor of LAWS directly translates to these weapons being seen as desirable, rather, their development is justified through the potential consequences of not possessing them. According to this logic, a state that chooses not to develop advanced military AI risks becoming vulnerable to states that do.

Russia's invasion of Ukraine can also provide an important backdrop to the self-defense reasoning used to legitimize LAWS, particularly by using the example of Ukraine's previous nuclear disarmament. The reason for this is that Ukraine used to house many of the Soviet Union's nuclear weapons during the Cold War. After giving up its nuclear arsenal in 1994 in exchange for security assurances from the United States, the UK and Russia, Ukraine later became exposed to Russian aggression despite the promises made to them (BBC 2024). Additionally, in the Russo-Ukrainian war, semi-autonomous and AI-enabled drone technologies have contributed to Ukraine's ability to compensate for shortages in military personnel (Miller 2025: 1). From a deterrence perspective, developing autonomous weapons can therefore be understood as a means of preventing aggression by ensuring that an attack would carry significant costs for one's adversaries, the same way possessing nuclear weapons does, especially for smaller countries that lack manpower and may be at the mercy of more powerful states.

So, there are reasonable grounds for the concern that restrictions on AI development could undermine strategic parity and this is only exasperated by Europe's turbulent security environment. Hence, even as these technologies regarded as undesirable from an ethical standpoint, they may be considered a non-negotiable if other states cannot be trusted to refrain from using them to exercise power over states that would prefer to maintain peace. Respondent No. 4 illustrates this reasoning by arguing that even if Sweden seeks to maintain peace, it must still be capable of defending itself against states that possess these technologies. The respondent questions how well international regulations can prevent harm and protect peace in practice, pointing out that international humanitarian law and existing rules of warfare are sometimes still violated. From this perspective, restricting Sweden's access to military AI could place it at a strategic disadvantage without guaranteeing that potential adversaries would exercise the same restraint.

> **Me:** "How do you view the fact that military systems are exempt from the EU's AI Act?"
>
> **Respondent No. 4:** "I see it positively. I think it is simply necessary [...] because of the very serious and dreadful events we are seeing in Ukraine, Israel and Iran. So, I think it's something we cannot avoid. [...] It [AI] is an advantage as well. For military purposes in particular. I am convinced that it is used both by Iran and the USA, [...] Russia and Ukraine, then we cannot have greater limitations than them. That would mean that we have a direct disadvantage as a civilized country that does not want war."
>
> **Me:** "What ethical or practical issues do you think they [LAWS] raise?"

> **Respondent No. 4:** "Above all human rights [...] the civilian population should always be protected, but not everyone does that; not everyone treats war as having any rules despite there being international laws."

This creates a recurring paradox within the discourse surrounding military AI. Autonomous weapons are justified as technologies that may deter conflict and protect populations, yet their deterrent value depends precisely on their capacity to inflict harm if conflict occurs. The discourse therefore shifts the question from whether autonomous weapons should be developed to whether states can afford not to develop them. Once the issue is framed in these terms, restraint becomes associated with vulnerability, while continued military AI development becomes easier to justify as an act of defense. This logic can consequently reproduce the very arms race dynamic that makes states feel compelled to develop LAWS in the first place. Respondent No. 6 describes a similar logic in Colombia, where people argue that if "we" do not develop autonomous weapons, they may eventually be used against us. The respondent describes this as a "weapons dilemma" and compares it to the development of nuclear weapons. In this manner, the AI arms race becomes a race to the bottom, as each actor pursues these technologies in the name of security, while their collective pursuit may ultimately make everyone less secure.

> **Respondent No. 6:** "It's a very complex topic. [...] everyone I've asked about this seems either very scared when they hear about it or they're kind of competitive, where they're always arguing, well, if we don't develop it, it could be used against us. It's a weapons dilemma. So, the logic is that if someone else is going to develop it, then we are behind. And of course, countries like ours, we're going to be behind anyway. But I can understand the situation with China and Russia, geopolitically, it's a hot situation. The worst part is that just like nuclear weapons [...] everybody will continue the arms race and we will implode. It will implode for all of us."

The respondent also raises an important caveat concerning the digital divide. They argue that countries in the so-called "Global South" often lack the resources to compete with wealthier or more technologically advanced states in AI development. Respondent No. 6 explains that this inequality also affects their ability to regulate emerging technologies discussing the AI Act, as some states lack the institutional and research capacity needed to develop comprehensive governance frameworks of their own, including for commercial and civilian AI systems. However, these differences in technological and military capacity may also shape states' interests in how autonomous weapons are regulated internationally. According to Bladell and Schmitt (2021), during the 2018 UN Group of Governmental Experts on LAWS in Geneva, states were divided over whether existing international humanitarian law provided sufficient protection from the potential dangers of LAWS. Several major military powers, including the United States and Russia, opposed negotiations towards new legally binding restrictions, while a coalition of 28 states supported a prohibition, with Austria, Brazil and Chile among those calling for negotiations on a legally binding instrument (Badell & Schmitt 2021: 249–250). This divide is significant because states do not enter debates over autonomous weapons

from equal technological or military positions. Thus, Respondent No. 6 illustrates how, to states with the inability to participate in the development of advanced military AI, limiting its proliferation may offer a different response to insecurity than attempting to compete with technologically dominant military powers. From a discourse analytical standpoint, this complicates the narrative of autonomous weapons as a competition in which all states have similar interests and circumstances.

The respondent similarly warns that the proliferation of these weapons increases the possibility of their use and misuse. Once such technologies have been developed, their application may also become increasingly difficult to contain, as the underlying systems can potentially be replicated, adapted, or appropriated by actors beyond those involved in their original development. This risk may be particularly pronounced where technological development occurs without effective institutional oversight or regulatory frameworks governing its production. They recall guerrilla groups in Colombia using machine guns equipped with sensory technology that, according to the respondent, fire when movement is detected. This raises a broader ethical question about the diffusion of increasingly autonomous weapons, particularly in regions where states may have limited capacity to regulate or control their use:

> **Respondent No. 6:** "I've heard recently that in the border of Colombia and Venezuela, the guerrillas are using, oh, I don't know what to call those, you know, those guns that go really fast."
>
> **Me:** "Yes, machine guns?"
>
> **Respondent No. 6:** "Machine guns, but with sensors that just shoot only with movement, they are no longer controlled by someone. They're just placed there and will shoot and these machine guns…I not sure if that's what it's called. I mean, for me, I consider it an automatized lethal weapon, right? I know that there are more sophisticated ones, but it is still very lethal and it's already in the hands of guerrillas in Latin America."

This demonstrates the value of including a global perspective in the analysis. The potential acquisition and misuse of LAWS by terrorist or non-state armed groups is somewhat absent from the Swedish policy documents examined in this study. When civilian misuse of AI is discussed, the focus instead falls primarily on fraud, disinformation and financial crimes (AI Commission 2024: 47–48). This may partly reflect the particular security context in which Swedish and broader European discussions of military AI take place, where concerns surrounding autonomous weapons do not necessarily emerge from experiences of guerrilla warfare or the widespread use of such technologies by non-state armed groups. Looking beyond this context can therefore broaden the range of risks considered, particularly as increasingly autonomous technologies may become more accessible. Respondent No. 6 thus adds an important perspective to the discussion by drawing

attention to how the proliferation of autonomous weapons in the absence of adequate legal frameworks could create security risks that are not yet prominent in Swedish national policy but may become increasingly relevant as these technologies develop.

While the ongoing conflicts in Europe and beyond cited by the respondents and policy documents provide reasonable grounds for concerns about national security and the need for states to defend themselves, acknowledging these concerns does not diminish the serious risks associated with autonomous weapons. Nor does it remove the need for greater international dialogue over how these technologies should be governed. As the account of Respondent No. 6 illustrates, once increasingly autonomous weapons are developed, there is also the possibility that they may spread beyond the institutions and actors for which they were originally intended, including through their acquisition by armed groups or terrorist organizations, or through interference by hackers. In such circumstances, assumptions that military AI will remain under the control of accountable state institutions cannot necessarily be extended to the actors who may subsequently acquire or gain control over these systems with civilians potentially bearing the consequences when that control is lost (AI Commission 2024: 48).

Security and Commercial Interests

The AI Act's defense exemption and the overall view of AI as a strategic requisite should be understood against Sweden's historical and geopolitical background. Although Sweden has not experienced war on its own territory for more than two centuries, its geographical proximity to the Soviet Union during the Cold War contributed to fears of a possible Soviet invasion. Given Sweden's geographical position along the Baltic Sea, Russia's military presence in Kaliningrad has long influenced Swedish defense thinking. These concerns encouraged the development of strong air force and naval capabilities (Coetzee 2017: 51–52). The fear of falling victim to Russian aggression has also been reinforced by more recent events. In June 2026, there were reports of Russian fighter jets near the Swedish border that had travelled from Kaliningrad, which led the Swedish Armed Forces to mobilize JAS Gripen aircrafts and issue warnings demanding that they leave Swedish territory. In an interview with SVT Nyheter (Swedish Television News), Ewa Skoog Haslum, Chief of Operations in the Swedish Armed Forces, stated that incidents such as these can be viewed as Russia testing Sweden's level of preparedness. She argued that Sweden's response sends a signal that Swedish defense is alert and ready to respond to potential hostile acts from other states (SVT Nyheter 2026). Such incidents give further legitimacy to Swedish security concerns about Russia's presence in the Baltic region. More notably, Russia's invasion of Ukraine and Sweden's accession to NATO have changed the country's security-policy environment to a large extent (AI Commission 2024: 46).

Against this background, it becomes easier to understand why Swedish AI policy increasingly presents AI not only as a tool for welfare, innovation and public-sector efficiency, but also as a strategic resource for national defense. When asked about how they viewed the AI Act's military

exemption, Respondent No. 4 stressed the importance of the exemption at a time when European security is being challenged by Russia and the global balance of power is changing as China and other non-western economies grow. The respondent asserts that a strong defense sector is necessary for securing peace. The respondent also points to the war in Ukraine as evidence of the strategic advantages offered by unmanned aerial vehicles, such as drones, enabled by AI technology. The Roadmap also speaks in the language of self-defense when discussing the development of LAWS.

This emphasis on defense rather than offensive power or military dominance reflects Sweden's long-standing international image as a neutral and humanitarian state, even though this discourse remains embedded within a Western-led international order from which Sweden benefits. Jarlert describes Sweden as a "peace-power state" whose modern national identity has been strongly associated with diplomacy and international peacebuilding, particularly through figures such as Dag Hammarskjöld and Folke Bernadotte (Jarlert 2014: 260). This image is present among the respondents as well. Respondent No. 3, for example, is not particularly concerned about what the military exemption could mean within the Swedish defense sector on account of their trust in the Swedish state.

> **Respondent No. 3:** "I see Sweden as a stable and democratically well-rooted country, where our values and our regard for humanity is held quite highly."

However, Sweden's peace-oriented international image exists alongside the country's long-standing defense industry. Coetzee argues that the image Sweden projects to the world has actually benefited Sweden's arms industry, particularly in relation to weapons exports. A central actor within this industry is Svenska Aeroplan Bolaget (The Swedish Aeroplane Corporation), often abbreviated as Saab, the Swedish defense and aerospace company that manufactures the JAS Gripen fighter aircraft (Coetzee 2017: 45). Sweden has maintained an advanced defense industry that depends heavily on international markets. According to a director of the Swedish Security and Defence Industry Association (SOFF) quoted by Coetzee, around 70% of Swedish-produced arms are exported, with access to foreign markets considered necessary for the survival of the domestic defense industry (Coetzee 2017: 47). Coetzee further describes how companies such as Saab have placed considerable pressure on the Swedish government to approve exports and international cooperation (Coetzee 2017: 47).

Likewise, Coetzee argues that Sweden's reputation provides an advantage in the global arms market because some states may prefer to purchase military equipment from a country associated with neutrality and non-alignment, as doing so can carry less political baggage than purchasing from a major military power. This has been particularly relevant for emerging economies in the Global South, where Sweden's lack of a significant colonial history may further contribute to its attractiveness as a defense partner (Coetzee 2017: 57).

> “Sweden has become very good at using its image to sell weapons, probably better than anyone else. Their success lies very much in the fact that buying nations usually assume that they are the good guys and everyone else are the bad guys. […] Procuring military hardware from a non-aligned country in the post-Cold war era means that there is potentially far less political baggage involved than when procuring from major weapons-exporting countries. As one Swedish government official put it, 'security policy implications are often more important than price. If you buy from the Americans there are lots of security policy implications' […] Emerging economies in the Global South are particularly cautious of military alliances with major powers with colonial histories.” (Coetzee 2017:57)

Although Saab is a private company, Coetzee shows that Sweden’s defense industry is closely connected to the state. The industry provides jobs, supports technological development and research and the Swedish state has an interest in keeping it competitive (Coetzee 2017: 54). This is also relevant when considering the military exemption in the AI Act. While the policy documents mainly present military AI development as necessary for national defense, allowing this technology to develop outside the rules of the AI Act may also benefit Sweden’s defense industry and its ability to develop new military technologies. But the economic and commercial interests connected to military AI are much less visible in the policy documents examined in this study.

Notably, the economic side of military innovation receives considerably less attention in discussions of military AI and the AI Act exemption. The most apparent argument is that Sweden needs to advance their AI capabilities and develop LAWS because it would otherwise be at a disadvantage compared with states that already possess them. This does not mean that the security concerns are not genuine. However, the exemption extends beyond state institutions to private companies developing AI systems exclusively for military or defense purposes. This is significant for the discourse analysis because, unlike democratic institutions, these companies may also have commercial interests in the continued development and sale of military technologies (Clapp 2025: 4). Yet, these economic interests are far less prominent in the discourse surrounding how Swedish policies justify the AI Act’s military exemption, which instead legitimizes military AI primarily through national security and citizens’ trust in state institutions. Thus, it is worth considering who benefits from military AI and who is expected to carry its risks.

In line with this, Respondent No. 4 suggests that attitudes towards the AI Act’s defense exemption may differ depending on a person’s position within the defense sector. The respondent says that those who profit from, or hold senior positions within, the Swedish defense industry and companies such as Saab may be more likely to view the exemption positively. By contrast, lower-ranking soldiers may be more concerned about being exposed to AI-enabled threats, such as drone attacks. This highlights how military AI applications can have very different implications depending on where an actor is located within the defense sector or chain of command. It also raises the possibility that AI armament could have unintended consequences for the country’s “will to defend”, which the AI Strategy aims to strengthen, if human soldiers feel increasingly vulnerable to technologies they

cannot control (Regeringskansliet 2026: 12). This concern is not entirely absent from Swedish policy discourse, although it is often framed more broadly. For example, the AI Commission's roadmap notes that AI-enabled military technologies may increase the risk of escalation and violence (AI Commission 2024:47). Although interviewing soldiers fall outside the scope of this study, their perspectives would be particularly valuable for future research, as they experience the consequences of increasingly autonomous warfare more directly than many of the actors involved in shaping its policy and regulation.

In this way, the respondent's comment on the uneven distribution of risk within the military raises a broader question of who benefits from military AI and who is expected to carry its risks. High-ranking defense actors, policymakers and companies may be more likely to view the AI Act's defense exemption as strategically necessary, in the name of security or commercial interests, while soldiers and civilians are perhaps more likely to become exposed to the consequences of the use of LAWS in modern warfare. While autonomous weapons may reduce casualties among combatants, it does not necessarily reduce the overall destruction caused by war. Historically, the loss of soldiers can generate considerable social and political pressure to end a conflict as casualties accumulate and these losses are felt by households and communities. If LAWS increasingly replace soldiers, some of this pressure may be reduced, but this is not to say that warfare conducted through autonomous systems would not still impose substantial political and economic costs. Rather, its consequences could increasingly be experienced by civilians and critical infrastructure, as winning a war ultimately depends on getting an opponent to capitulate (Stop Killer Robots 2025). This makes the role of civilians important not only in terms of who may experience the consequences of autonomous warfare, but also in terms of how the public understands and responds to the development of these technologies.

Questions about public understanding also emerged during the observation phase of the empirical research as well, specifically at a lecture on AI given by Respondent No. 1, where an audience member expressed concern over what autonomous weapons could mean for the future. Others also expressed that they saw AI as a bit of an enigma. This reflects a more civilian discourse on AI, where limited technical knowledge may leave public understanding of AI shaped largely by the outlets available to them, including the news, social media and or word of mouth. This differs from the respondents, whose occupations give them at least some exposure to AI and its regulations. In this context, autonomous weapons may become associated with dystopian fears about AI among Swedish citizens as the secrecy surrounding military technologies can make it difficult for the public to gain a more informed understanding of their actual capabilities and use. This has democratic implications, because if citizens have limited access to information about these technologies, it becomes more difficult for them to participate meaningfully in debates about their development.

This raises the question of who has access to the knowledge needed to participate in these discussions. During the interview process, several respondents expressed that they were unfamiliar with some of the questions surrounding the military and hesitated to speak about military AI at all. They described themselves as lacking sufficient knowledge of defense matters. Respondent No. 2, a

digitalization strategist in Sweden, for example, said that they did not feel entitled to participate in an interview concerning these issues. Some respondents justified their unfamiliarity by pointing out that certain information concerning the defense sector is kept confidential for good reason, such as to prevent sensitive information from reaching foreign actors. And debates surrounding the ethics of LAWS tend to take place at institutional and organizational levels. This may affect who feels entitled to participate in discussions about military AI. This is particularly relevant to Foucault's understanding of discourse as a form of power. As quoted by Fairclough, Foucault argues that discourse is not simply a reflection of struggles over power, but that discourse itself is the power which is to be seized (Fairclough 1992: 50). In this case, the issue is not necessarily that some military information is confidential, but that even non-confidential ethical debates in which the public could participate receive limited attention in open political debate and the media. The respondents' limited access to these discussions may therefore contribute to an idea that military expertise is a prerequisite when thinking about and speak on military AI, even though its ethical implications extend beyond these institutions. Inadvertently, those with greater access to specialized military knowledge and institutional debates may, in turn, have greater authority to shape how military AI is understood and discussed.

AI Literacy in Sweden

Now that we have discussed the potential implications of LAWS as an area excluded from the AI Act, the Swedish government's vision for integrating AI into society and the discourse surrounding AI in Sweden and globally, the discussion turns to AI literacy. The AI Act defines AI literacy as the skills, knowledge and understanding that enable people to use AI systems in an informed manner and understand both the opportunities and potential harms associated with AI technology, making increased AI literacy one of its objectives (AI Act 2024: Art. 4). The Roadmap proposes investing approximately SEK 2 billion in AI literacy initiatives in Sweden, making it one of the largest areas of proposed investment, after AI research and public-sector AI (AI Commission 2024: 121). This is particularly relevant to this study, partly because it aims to assess AI literacy within the Swedish public sector and partly because the Roadmap emphasizes that the potential weaponization of AI extends beyond autonomous weapons. Beyond its use in LAWS, AI can be weaponized by hostile state actors to conduct cyberattacks and sabotage, facilitate unauthorized intelligence gathering of classified information and carry out disinformation campaigns intended to undermine trust in public institutions, weaken social cohesion and potentially manipulate election outcomes (AI Commission 2024: 47–48). AI literacy is therefore presented as one means of making society more resilient to such threats. The Roadmap states that increasing AI literacy is necessary if Sweden is to fully benefit from the technology. It also presents AI literacy as a means of helping individuals recognize risks such as fraud and disinformation, as well as bias in automated decision-making. The Roadmap argues that improved AI literacy can reduce existing knowledge gaps and prevent new ones from emerging (AI Commission 2024: 62–63). The AI Strategy likewise presents AI literacy as important for Sweden's future labor market and connects it to digital inclusion and national resilience. The strategy argues that media and information literacy can limit the spread of AI-generated disinformation and strengthen societal resilience against polarization (Regeringskansliet 2026: 11–17).

In regard to mapping AI literacy from the perspectives of public-sector professionals, the respondents generally describe AI literacy as uneven, although they differ in how serious they believe the knowledge gap to be. Respondent No. 1 gives the most negative assessment, estimating general public knowledge at around “three out of ten” and drawing a strong generational distinction as they believe that younger people and those exposed to AI through their work have considerably more knowledge than pensioners. They place particular importance on schools, workshops and public-sector training to remedy this phenomenon. Respondent No. 2 has a more positive outlook and describes public knowledge as relatively high because AI is now discussed across age groups. However, the respondent's understanding of literacy goes beyond simply knowing about AI. Respondent No. 2 stresses source criticism, ethical use and the ability to avoid being deceived by AI-generated content. They also describe municipal initiatives aimed specifically at school pupils, teachers and people over 75, suggesting that some groups still require more support despite their positive overall assessment.

Respondent No. 5, a librarian at a Swedish university, similarly describes knowledge as highly uneven. Among university students, the respondent encounters both enthusiastic AI users and people who strongly distrust it, while outside academia they are concerned by people using ChatGPT as a source of information for almost everything. For them, the issue is not that people aren’t AI literate in the sense that people don't know how to use AI tools, rather, they identify the lack of critical thinking about the information it produces as the main concern. They believe that this issue can be resolved through education, since students report greater knowledge and confidence after AI-literacy lectures, in their own experience.

> **Respondent No. 5:** “When I’m around ordinary people, so to speak, or talking to friends who are not academics, I sometimes become a little frightened when I hear how they use AI for practically everything. They ask ChatGPT questions and then simply accept the answers they get from it. So, I think there is quite a low level of critical thinking about the information people get when using AI.”

The Roadmap proposes approximately SEK 2 billion for initiatives related to AI literacy, but in spite of this, Respondent No. 5 draws attention to a gap between these investments and how responsibility for AI literacy is experienced at the institutional level. Although libraries are expected to contribute to increasing AI literacy, the respondent argues that this responsibility has not necessarily been accompanied by sufficient resources. In their university library, staff have educated students about AI since 2023, but according to the respondent, this work has been carried out using existing resources rather than additional funding. Their criticism is not directed at the goal of increasing AI literacy, which they strongly support, but at placing responsibility on institutions without necessarily providing them with the practical capacity to fulfil it. As the Roadmap was published in 2024, the staff was definitely ahead of the game, so to speak, which could explain why they hadn’t received funding for their efforts. Still, the respondent says that plenty of funding goes to AI

researchers, but not to those raising AI literacy among staff and students. This is particularly significant because of the challenges they have with AI-use at their institution. Respondent No. 5 describes students uploading copyrighted literatue and course material to generative AI tools such as ChatGPT and NotebookLM, while Respondent No. 1 similarly raises cases in which students may unknowingly disclose confidential company information to AI chatbots during internships or research collaborations, despite having signed non-disclosure agreements, because they are unaware of how certain chatbots store and process the data submitted to them or uses it as training data. AI literacy can therefore be viewed as more than knowing how to operate an AI system. It also requires understanding what information can safely and legally be shared with these systems and what consequences can follow when such knowledge is lacking.

These examples add an important practical dimension to the policy discourse surrounding AI literacy. National strategies can identify AI competence as a priority and allocate substantial resources towards it, but their effects ultimately depend on how these ambitions are translated into everyday institutional practice. Respondent No. 5's experience suggests that some of this responsibility is already being taken on from below by librarians, educators and other public-sector professionals because they encounter the consequences of AI use directly in their work. Almost all of the respondents placed responsibility for promoting AI literacy on the state and public-sector institutions, particularly schools and libraries. Respondent No. 5 similarly emphasizes that this is an institutional responsibility that requires sufficient time, training and resources. The respondent asserts that the policy ambition to increase AI literacy depends not only on individual willingness to learn, but also on whether the institutions expected to provide this knowledge are given the capacity to do so (Regeringskansliet 2026: 15).

Furthermore, Respondent No. 4 believes public knowledge is improving quickly but argues that major misunderstandings remain. They point to both excessive trust in AI outputs and exaggerated "science-fiction" fears about AI becoming conscious or taking over the world as two ends of the same spectrum. They too see younger people as potentially more AI literate than older generations because children are becoming accustomed to identifying AI-generated images and other synthetic content, although they still argue that knowledge of AI policy, appropriate uses and broader implications remains weak. Respondent No. 3 makes a distinction between knowing that AI exists and knowing how to use it meaningfully. They believe many people can use AI for entertainment, making travel plans or simple information searches, while fewer know how to integrate it more practically into everyday life in a way that provides the productivity that AI is supposed to enable. The respondent also identifies a generational divide, arguing that older people may find AI frightening or avoid using it altogether, while younger people need a support that is more focused on source criticism, risks and avoiding excessive overdependence on AI. Respondent No. 6 similarly believes public understanding in Colombia has improved from a very low level and is increasing, but remains insufficient. Their concern is that "AI" is marketed as a simple and transformative technology despite being technically complex, making it difficult for the public to distinguish between different forms and capabilities of AI. They also underline that gaps in access to AI systems and AI literacy both across and within nations may reproduce or exacerbate existing social

inequalities and stresses the importance of understanding that automated decisions are not inherently neutral.

Overall, the findings suggest that AI literacy cannot simply be understood as awareness of or the ability to use AI tools. Across the interviews, meaningful AI literacy was also associated with critical thinking, understanding the limitations and risks of AI and knowing how to use these technologies responsibly. Differences in age, education, professional exposure and access to technology also appear to create different levels of AI literacy in our societies. This makes AI literacy not only a question of individual competence, but also one of inclusion, as those with less knowledge or access may be unable to benefit from AI or critically engage with its growing role in society.
The findings also suggest that building a society capable of adapting to AI requires investment not only in the technology and the researchers developing it, but also in the people and institutions responsible for increasing public understanding. Technological development alone does not ensure that AI will benefit society if people lack the knowledge needed to use it safely and critically. Different groups may face different risks, from older people being more vulnerable to AI-enabled scams to younger people encountering AI-generated disinformation.

With regard to the discourse on AI in Sweden, the interviews also show that understandings of AI are not uniform. Some respondents describe enthusiasm about its possibilities, while others point to fear, distrust and exaggerated perceptions of what AI can do. Rather than treating AI as either inherently beneficial or inherently threatening, the findings point toward a more cautiously optimistic understanding that recognizes its potential to increase productivity and improve everyday life while maintaining source criticism and awareness of its limitations and risks. Greater AI literacy may therefore also contribute to a more nuanced public discourse, in which people are better equipped to question both overly optimistic claims about AI and exaggerated fears surrounding the technology.

CONCLUSION

This thesis set out to examine how the defense exemption in the EU's AI Act is constructed in Swedish and European policy discourse, how military AI and lethal autonomous weapons systems (LAWS) are framed in relation to security and ethics and what role AI literacy plays in public understanding and participation. The findings show that these questions are closely connected. How AI is spoken about affects which risks receive attention, which actors are trusted to manage them. The defense exemption is mainly made justified through national security and the responsibility of the state to protect its population. Within this framing, the military is treated differently from civilian institutions because the defense-sector is understood to be entitled to secrecy, flexibility and access to the most advanced technologies available. This reasoning has become more convincing in a security environment shaped by Russia's invasion of Ukraine, Sweden's NATO membership and

the development of military AI by other states. Several respondents were uncomfortable with autonomous weapons but still argued that Sweden cannot place greater restrictions on itself if potential adversaries do not do the same. Thus, military AI is often justified not because it is considered desirable, but because not developing it is presented as a security risk. This is one of the clearest findings of the study. The question shifts from whether states should develop increasingly autonomous weapons to whether they can afford not to.

The same logic appears in the wider discourse surrounding an international AI "arms race." Swedish policy does not explicitly use this term, but it repeatedly speaks of leading states, international competition and the fear of Sweden or Europe falling behind. This language makes continued technological development appear necessary. It can also make restraint harder to imagine because one state's decision to limit military AI does not guarantee that others will do the same. Respondent No. 6 shows that this reasoning extends beyond states that are capable of leading the technological competition. In Colombia, the respondent encounters the same argument that autonomous weapons may be necessary because other countries will develop them anyway, despite recognizing that countries with fewer resources are likely to lose this race. The arms race discourse can therefore reproduce itself even among those who don't stand to gain from the arms race framing.

This does not mean that the security arguments identified in the study are unsubstantiated. AI may strengthen defense, improve surveillance and decision-making, protect soldiers and potentially make some military operations more precise. The war in Ukraine also shows why smaller states may see advanced technologies as a way of compensating for disadvantages in manpower or military capacity. Yet the analysis shows that the promise of greater security comes with risks of its own. Dependence on AI creates dependence on data centers, semiconductors, foreign technology and global supply chains. Technologies developed by states can spread to non-state actors. Systems intended to improve precision can fail, be interfered with or operate in circumstances their designers did not anticipate. Hence, it is important to note that increasing military autonomy may solve certain security problems while creating new ones. The Roadmap shows the greatest awareness to the nuances of military AI while the AI Strategy focuses on the strategic benefits.

The ethical issue that respondents returned to most consistently was not AI in warfare itself, but the point at which human judgment and responsibility disappear from lethal decisions. Most respondents accepted that AI could have legitimate military uses while expressing concern about allowing a system to independently decide who should be killed. This distinction matters as a weapon that protects civilians by intercepting an incoming missile raises different questions from a system that identifies and attacks human targets without human approval. The findings do not support a simple division between being for or against military AI. They point instead to meaningful human control, accountability and compliance with international humanitarian law as central questions in deciding where military autonomy is acceptable or unacceptable in their personal opinion.

At the same time, international governance remains caught in the same security logic that drives military AI development. States have different military capabilities, security concerns and interests, which makes agreement on binding restrictions difficult. Major military powers may have less incentive to restrict technologies in which they hold an advantage, while states with fewer resources may have more to gain from limiting their proliferation. This challenges the idea of an AI arms race in which every country is simply running the same race from a different position. Countries enter these debates with unequal resources and unequal exposure to the risks, which speaks to how discourse can reproduce existing structures of power. The consequences are also unevenly distributed within states. Defense companies may benefit commercially from military innovation, governments may gain new strategic capabilities and soldiers may be protected from some forms of danger, while other soldiers and civilians may become exposed to new forms of automated warfare. Sweden's defense industry adds another dimension to this finding as national security is highly visible in the justification of military AI development, while the commercial interests that can also benefit from continued military innovation receive much less attention.

These perceptions of AI and autonomous weapons matter for understanding the AI Act's defense exemption and lack of LAWS regulation globally. This should not be read as evidence that military AI is unregulated or that ethical concerns are absent among regulatory bodies in Europe and beyond. The AI Commission openly recognizes the dangers of autonomous weapons and the lack of binding international laws. The more significant finding is that military AI is placed outside a regulatory framework that otherwise treats risk, transparency and accountability as reasons for stronger oversight. National security provides the main explanation for this difference. The exemption therefore shows how the same technology can be governed differently depending on the purpose attached to it and the institutions using it. In Foucauldian terms, security discourse helps establish the conditions under which this exceptional treatment becomes reasonable.

The question of who can participate in that discourse became important during the interviews. Several respondents who were knowledgeable about AI still hesitated to discuss military AI because they did not consider themselves sufficiently informed about defense. Some secrecy is necessary in military affairs, but ethical questions about autonomous weapons are not themselves military secrets. If people come to believe that military expertise is required before they can discuss whether a machine should be allowed to make lethal decisions, an issue with consequences for the wider public can become concentrated among military, political and technical institutions. Those with greater access to specialized knowledge then have greater opportunities to define the terms through which military AI is understood.

On top of that, AI literacy is regarded as more than a question of learning how to use ChatGPT. The respondents describe very different levels of knowledge across age groups, professions and social settings, but repeatedly return to the importance of critical thinking. Knowing how to generate an answer with AI is of limited value if a person cannot judge whether the answer is reliable, recognize manipulated content, understand what information should not be uploaded to an AI service or question the assumption that an automated decision is neutral and not subject to bias and existing

structures of inequality. Access to AI and the ability to use it are therefore not the same as being AI literate. For this reason, investment in AI research and infrastructure needs to be accompanied by serious investment in the people who teach the public how to live with these technologies. The experience of Respondent No. 5 reveals that librarians were already educating students about AI and dealing with its consequences in everyday academic life, while doing so using their own budget. On that account, developing advanced AI systems will not by itself create a society capable of using them well. Schools, libraries, universities and public institutions that build AI literacy are part of the same process. If that side is neglected, technological development may increase productivity for those able to benefit from it while leaving other groups more exposed to fraud, disinformation, unsafe use and exclusion.

Finally, the interviews show why neither technological optimism nor fear provides an adequate basis for understanding AI. Some respondents encountered people who trusted AI too easily, while others encountered people whose understanding was shaped by science-fiction. A more useful public discourse lies between these positions. AI can improve productivity, public services and national defense but despite this, that does not mean that every AI application is beneficial simply because it is technologically advanced. Likewise, recognizing the risks of AI does not require rejecting the technology as a whole.

The broader conclusion of this thesis is therefore that the central political question surrounding AI is not simply whether it should be developed. AI is already being developed, adopted and incorporated into civilian and military institutions. What matters now is how societies decide which forms of AI to pursue and where limits should be drawn. These decisions also involve questions of power and responsibility, since the benefits and risks of AI are not distributed equally and not everyone has the same opportunity to influence its development. Given the disruptive nature of the technology, sufficient public knowledge and participation are therefore important for ensuring that these decisions are not left solely to the institutions and actors with the greatest technological, political or economic power. The defense exemption makes these questions especially critical because it places some of the most grim uses of AI outside the EU's main AI regulatory framework. AI literacy, meaningful human control and open public debate cannot resolve every problem raised by military AI, but without them, decisions about technologies that may reshape both everyday life and warfare risk being made by a narrow group of actors. With that said, the study has identified how meaningful political and ethical choices remain important, even when technological development is increasingly presented as something that cannot be avoided.

APPENDIX

The semi-structured interview guide used to conduct the interviews with the respondents is presented below.

1. Background and Context

1.1 Professional Role and Responsibilities

- Can you describe your current professional role and the types of issues you work on within the public sector?
- How long have you worked in this field?
- Has your role changed as digitalization and AI have developed?

1.2 Experience with AI

- How, if at all, do you encounter AI in your work?
- What types of tools or systems are involved?
- Do you also use AI in your personal life? If so, how?

1.3 AI in the Organization

- How would you describe the use of AI in your organization today?
- Can you give concrete examples of processes or decisions where AI is used?
- In which areas is AI not used and why?

2. Governance, Risk and Democracy

2.1 Risks and Risk Management

- What opportunities and risks do you see with AI in the public sector?

- How are issues such as data protection and confidentiality handled?
- Are there clear guidelines that you are required to follow?

2.2 Democratic Decision-Making

- How do you think AI could affect democratic processes and decision-making?
- Could AI also strengthen democracy? If so, how?

2.3 National Governance

- What role do you think national strategies play in practice? (Sweden's AI Strategy and the AI Commission's Roadmap for Sweden)
- Have they had any concrete impact on your work?

3. The EU's AI Act (EU) 2024/1689

3.1 Awareness and Understanding

- How would you describe your own knowledge of the EU's AI Act?
- Where have you received information about it?

3.2 Practical Implications

- What impact do you think the regulation will have on your organization?
- Are there areas where you will need to make adjustments?
- Do you see any challenges in implementing it?

3.3 Views on Regulation

- How do you perceive the balance between innovation and regulation in the EU's AI Act?
- Is it too strict, too weak, or reasonable?

3.4 Sweden's Role in the EU

- How do you perceive Sweden's influence on the EU's work on AI regulation?
- Do you think Sweden should promote a particular position?

4. Military AI and Security

4.1 Exemption for Military Systems

- What is your view on military AI systems being exempt from the EU's AI Act?
- What arguments do you see for and against this exemption?

4.2 Security Policy Implications

- What consequences do you think this could have for Sweden from a security or defense perspective?

4.3 Regulation of Military AI

- How do you think AI in the military should be regulated, if at all?

4.4 Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS)

- What is your view of autonomous weapons systems?
- What ethical or practical questions do they raise?
- How could they affect security policy?

5. AI Literacy and Society

5.1 AI Knowledge in Society

- How would you assess the public's knowledge of AI today?

5.2 The Role of the State

- What role should the government play in increasing AI literacy in Swedish society?

5.3 The Public Sector's Responsibility

- What responsibility does the public sector have for increasing understanding of AI?
- Has your organization undertaken any initiatives to do so?

5.4 Future Perspectives

- How important do you think digital literacy and understanding of AI will become in Sweden in the future?

6. Conclusion

6.1 Additional Insights

- Is there anything we have not discussed that you think is important?

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